



America Turns 250

The Family Celebration & Discussion Kit

\$7.00 · INSTANT DIGITAL DOWNLOAD

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The 10-Minute Celebration Guide

How to lead a small America-250 moment at any gathering — a cookout, a Sunday dinner, a classroom, or a holiday table. No preparation, no history degree. Just read the bold lines aloud.

You are the host. The whole thing takes about ten minutes. Do as much or as little as your group wants. Every fact below is checked — see `.sources.md`.

Before you start (30 seconds of setup)

- Print this page and the discussion questions (`02-discussion-and-keepsake.md`).
 - Optional: have the founding texts on hand to read aloud (our **Founding Documents Reader** is built for exactly this; or use any public-domain copy of the Declaration's opening lines).
 - Pour something to toast with — anything counts.
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STEP 1 — The Welcome (1 minute)

Read aloud:

> "Before we eat, one quick thing. This year, 2026, America turns 250 years old. Two hundred and > fifty years ago, in 1776, a group of ordinary people signed their names to a promise — that we'd > govern ourselves. We're still here. So tonight, let's take two minutes to be glad about that > together."

STEP 2 — The Read-Aloud Moment (2-3 minutes)

Pick ONE of these. Hand it to a good reader — a grandparent or a kid who wants the spotlight.

Option A — The most famous sentence in America. Read the Declaration's second sentence aloud:

> "We hold these truths to be self-evident, that all men are created equal, that they are endowed by > their Creator with certain unalienable Rights, that among these are Life, Liberty and the pursuit > of Happiness." > — The Declaration of Independence, adopted July 4, 1776

Then ask the table: "**250 years later — how are we doing on that promise?**" (Keep it warm. This is gratitude, not debate.)

Option B — The prediction that came true. Read this aloud:

> In a letter home on July 3, 1776, John Adams predicted that the birth of the nation would be > celebrated forever after "with Pomp and Parade... Bonfires and Illuminations from one End of this > Continent to the other." He was picturing exactly what your family is doing right now.

Then ask: **"What's your favorite way America celebrates?"**

Option C — The unbroken promise. Read this aloud:

> In one small town — Bristol, Rhode Island — Americans have celebrated the Fourth of July every > single year since 1785, the oldest continuous Independence Day celebration in the country. Two > years after the Revolution ended, a war veteran started it, and the town has never missed a year > since — right up to America's 250th.

Then ask: **"What's a tradition our family has never missed?"**

STEP 3 — Go Around the Table (3-4 minutes)

Open `02-discussion-and-keepsake.md` and let each person answer ONE question from their age tier. Start with the youngest and end with the oldest — the elders' answers are the ones everyone remembers. Don't rush it. If a story starts, let it run.

STEP 4 — The Keepsake (1 minute)

Pass around the **"We Marked America's 250th" certificate** (in `02-discussion-and-keepsake.md`). Fill in who's here, the date, and one wish for America's next hundred years. Sign it. Keep it or frame it — this is the proof your family was present for the semiquincentennial.

STEP 5 — The Toast (30 seconds)

Raise your glass and read aloud:

> **"To 250 years — and to the people at this table, who keep the story going. Happy Birthday, > America."**

That's it. Now eat.

Want to keep it going? Our Great American Trivia Pack (100 questions) turns the rest of the evening into a game, and the Founding Documents Reader gives you the full texts to read aloud. Links where you bought this.

Discussion Questions, Living History Interview & Keepsake Certificate

Original conversation starters — no right or wrong answers, no politics. Built to draw out stories, gratitude, and memory across three generations. Pride, not argument.

PART 1 — 40 FAMILY DISCUSSION QUESTIONS (tiered by age)

Let each person pick a question from their tier and answer out loud. Elders answer last.

Tier 1 — Little Ones (ages 4-8)

1. What are the three colors of the American flag?
2. What's your favorite thing about the Fourth of July?
3. If you could wave a giant flag anywhere, where would you wave it?
4. What sound do fireworks make? Can you make it?
5. Who is the oldest person in our family here today? Go give them a high-five.
6. What's one thing that makes our family special?
7. If America had a birthday cake, how many candles would it need this year?
(Answer: 250!)
8. What's a job you'd like to have that helps other people?

Tier 2 — Kids & Teens (ages 9-17)

1. If you had to explain to a kid from another country what makes America special, what would you say?
2. The Declaration says people have a right to "the pursuit of happiness." What does happiness mean to you?
3. Who is a real American — famous or not — that you admire, and why?
4. If you could ask a Founder one question, what would you ask?
5. What's something you're proud America has done? What's something you hope it does better?
6. What tradition do you hope our family still has when YOU are a grandparent?
7. If you designed a monument for something ordinary Americans do, what would it honor?
8. What do you hope America looks like when it turns 300 — the year 2076?
9. What's a freedom you'd miss most if you didn't have it?
10. What song, place, or picture feels the most "American" to you?

Tier 3 — Grown-Ups (ages 18+)

1. What's the most patriotic thing you've ever seen in person?
2. When did you first feel proud to be an American?
3. Who in your life best represents what you love about this country?
4. What's a small, everyday freedom you're grateful for but rarely think about?
5. What do you want the next generation at this table to carry forward?
6. What's a hard chapter of American history that you think we became better for facing?
7. If you could witness one moment from the last 250 years in person, which would it be?
8. What does "the pursuit of happiness" look like in your own life right now?
9. What's one thing you hope is written about our era 250 years from now?
10. Who's someone in our own family whose story deserves to be remembered?

Tier 4 — Elders (the questions everyone remembers)

1. What do you remember about the Bicentennial in 1976 — where were you?
2. What's the biggest change in America you've seen in your lifetime?
3. What's the most American thing you ever saw or did?
4. Who in our family came before us that we should all know about?
5. What did the Fourth of July look like when you were a child?
6. What's a piece of advice you'd want read aloud at this table 50 years from now?
7. What are you most grateful for about the life you've been able to live here?
8. What do you hope your grandchildren never take for granted?
9. If you could send a message to the family that gathers for America's 300th birthday, what would it be?
10. What's a tradition you hope we never let die?
11. What made you proudest to be part of this country?
12. What would you want your name remembered for?

PART 2 — THE LIVING HISTORY INTERVIEW

Sit the youngest person who can write (or record on a phone) down with the oldest person at the gathering. Ask these slowly. Write the answers here and keep this page — it becomes more precious every year.

Person interviewed: _____ **Interviewed by:** _____

_____ **Date:** _____ **Where:** _____

1. Where and when were you born, and what was the world like then?

1. What do you remember about America's Bicentennial in 1976?

1. What historical event did you live through that you'll never forget?

1. Who is the most patriotic or hardest-working person you ever knew?

1. What's a family story you want to make sure never gets lost?

1. What do you hope for America — and for this family — over the next 100 years?

Tip: take a photo of the two of you together and keep it with this page.

PART 3 — THE "WE MARKED AMERICA'S 250TH" KEEPSAKE CERTIFICATE

*Fill it in, sign it, date it. Keep it or frame it — this is the proof your family was here for the
semiquincentennial. America was founded in 1776; $1776 + 250 = 2026$.*

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WE CELEBRATED AMERICA'S 250TH BIRTHDAY 1776 - 2026

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On this day, _____ (date), our family and friends gathered at
_____ (place) to mark 250 years of the
United States of America.

Those who were here:

Our one wish for America's next 100 years:

Signed by the eldest present: _____ Signed by the
youngest present: _____

"Happy Birthday, America - 250 years."

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Every historical figure and date mentioned in these questions is a matter of public record; the few factual prompts (1776, the 250th, the Bicentennial in 1976, Bristol RI since 1785) are verified in `.sources.md`. The questions themselves are original and opinion-based by design.